

The Problem

Booking corporate travel can feel like a full-time job in itself. You're juggling flight options that never quite align with your schedule, hotel availability that vanishes the moment you find something decent, and rental car pick-up times that always conflict with your arrival. Each step is a maze of comparison sites, corporate policies, and last-minute changes. And just when you think the hard part is over, the expense report looms. You dig through crumpled receipts, decipher charges, and try to remember if that airport coffee was personal or business. It's a tedious, time-consuming process that turns every trip into a logistical headache before, during, and long after you've returned.

How might we solve this?

We're designing an agent—or a suite of agents—to help employees organize, book, and expense corporate travel. The system will know each user's preferences and profile, and it will be aware of colleagues' itineraries for the same trip. Based on destination and dates, it will propose flights, a hotel, a rental car if needed, restaurants that match your tastes and per-diem, and any requested team meals. The user can approve or adjust the selections, and the system will start drafting your expense report. While traveling, snap a photo of each receipt and upload it; the tool will parse the details and add them to the report. Once you're back, simply review and submit.

Section 1: Proposal Statement

Employees often struggle with the complexities and time-consuming nature of organizing and booking corporate travel. This process involves finding suitable flights, accommodations, transport, meal suggestions, and subsequent expense reporting—tasks that can be tedious and error-prone, especially when coordinating with colleagues' itineraries.

Our solution targets employees and travel coordinators, automating the travel planning process to enhance efficiency and reduce the burden on employees. Users interact with our agentic AI through an intuitive, user-friendly interface where they input travel preferences, dates, and any special requirements. The system will then autonomously handle the entire planning process, from flight and hotel selection to restaurant recommendations, per-diem calculation, and expense report drafting.

Agentic AI is essential for this solution due to its ability to learn from past travel patterns, preferences, and company policies. It can proactively propose tailor-made travel arrangements, anticipate users' needs, and adapt to real-time changes (e.g., flight delays, rescheduling). Unlike rule-based systems, agentic AI can handle nuances, unpredictability, and complexities inherent in corporate travel booking and expense management.

By implementing this AI-driven travel solution, we anticipate a significant reduction in travel-related administrative tasks, saving employees valuable time and minimizing stress. Enhanced personalization and real-time collaboration features will streamline decision-making among colleagues sharing the same destination. Ultimately, this innovation will improve overall employee satisfaction, promote accurate expense reporting, and contribute to cost savings.

Section 2: Technical Statement

Our solution will consist of a suite of AI agents, each dedicated to different aspects of the travel planning and expense management process. The primary agents include:

Travel Preference Agent: This agent learns from individual user preferences, past travel patterns, and corporate policies to propose personalized travel options.

Collaborative Itinerary Agent: This agent facilitates seamless coordination between colleagues traveling to the same destination by identifying overlapping itineraries and suggesting shared transport or accommodation options.

Expense Report Agent: This agent drafts expense reports based on approved travel selections, automatically categorizing and summing expenses. It also integrates with receipt parsing technology to extract details and populate the report.

Integration with Watsonx Orchestrate: Watsonx Orchestrate serves as the central nervous system, enabling agents to collaborate, share data, and maintain a coherent understanding of user preferences, travel policies, and real-time updates. The platform's robust data management capabilities ensure that agents access accurate and up-to-date information from diverse data sources, such as flight databases, hotel APIs, and internal expense guidelines.

Agent Collaboration and User Interaction: Agents work in tandem, continuously exchanging information and adapting to user inputs. For instance, the Travel Preference Agent suggests options, which the user approves or modifies. The Collaborative Itinerary Agent identifies shared itineraries, while the Expense Report Agent parses receipts and drafts the report. User interaction is facilitated through a dedicated mobile app and web interface, ensuring a seamless experience across devices.

Capabilities, Tools, and Integrations: To deliver a comprehensive solution, our agentic AI suite relies on various tools and integrations, such as:

- Natural Language Processing (NLP) for understanding user preferences and requests
- Machine learning algorithms for personalized recommendations and predictive analysis
- API integrations with flight databases, hotel booking platforms, and rental car services
- Receipt parsing and expense categorization capabilities

- Secure data storage and sharing mechanisms, adhering to IBM's data governance policies

By leveraging Watsonx Orchestrate, our solution ensures seamless agent collaboration, efficient data management, and a user-centric approach to corporate travel planning and expense management.